EASTERN SECTOR

Difficulty: POSSIBLE WITH CAVEATS

SIKKIM

A 220-km section of the boundary has no dispute, but there are serious flashpoints in Northeastern Sikkim

NAKU LA: Mountain pass in north Sikkim, site of clashes between patrols in 2020 and 2021

THE TRIJUNCTION of India, Bhutan and China is still a bone of contention. Northeast of this point lies the Doklam plateau, which saw a major clash in 2017 when India halted Chinese road works to Jampheri ridge heights, endangering the Siliguri Corridor—India's connect to its NE

Difficulty: EXTREMELY HIGH

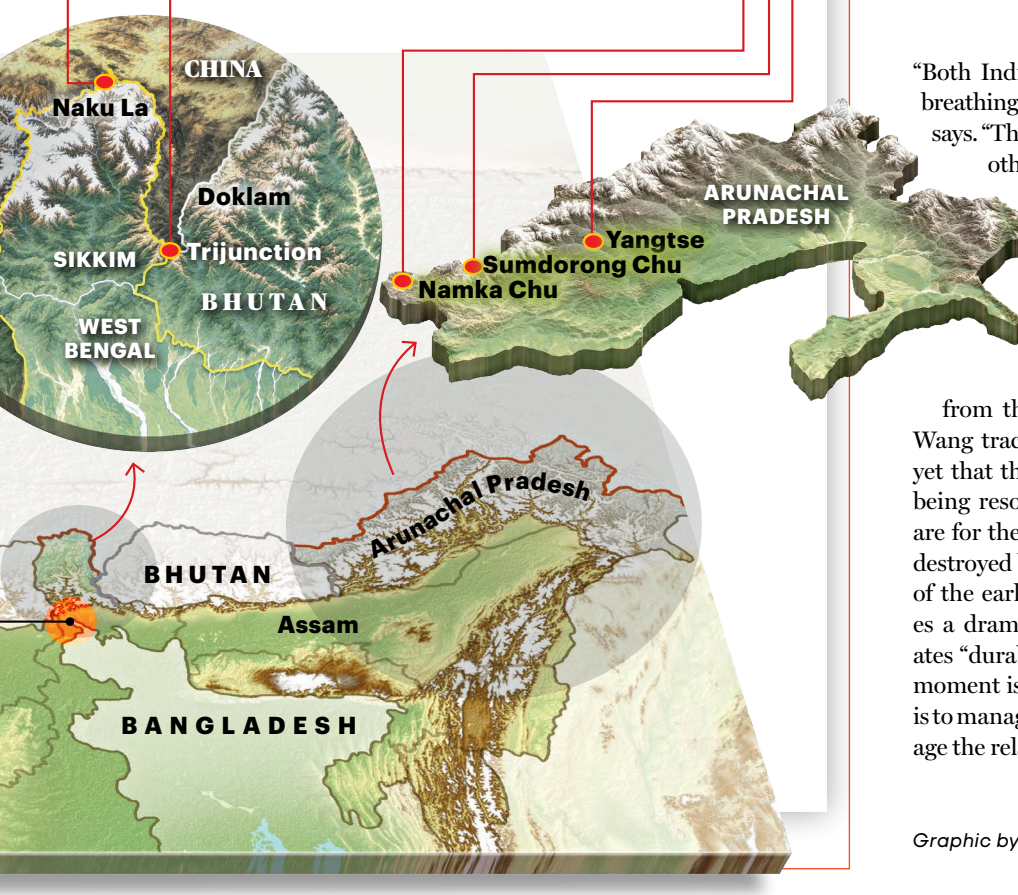
ARUNACHAL PRADESH

China has not accepted the 890 km-long McMahon Line between Arunachal and Tibet and calls the state 'South Tibet'

TAWANG/ YANGTSE Where Dalai Lama entered India, it is central to Chinese demands. In 2022, China tried to claim a ridge in Yangtse on the McMahon Line, repulsed

SUMDORONG CHU VALLEY: Large Chinese incursion in 1986-87 that led to a years-long standoff that saw full resolution only in 1995

BUM LA, NAMKA CHU, THAG LA RIDGE: Sites of fierce battles in 1962; border remains contested and armed



Yet others see India's motives as more prosaic: wanting a quieter border and renewed economic opportunities with China that will give it greater room for manoeuvre in an unusually turbulent world. Says Shyam Saran, a former foreign secretary who helped negotiate the 2005 framework that still governs India-China border talks, "Given the current geopolitical situation, both sides have an interest in being seen as not antithetical to each other." Former national security advisor Shivshankar Menon agrees.



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EINAR TANGEN, *Chinese commentator*

"Both Indian and Chinese governments want breathing room and want to be left in peace," he says. "The message is, 'let's not clash as we have other, bigger fish to fry'." He concedes that the "modest ambition exhibited by the two recently represents an important change" but says it is not by itself a strategic shift.

Einar Tangen, a Beijing-based geopolitics commentator who has watched the relationship from the Chinese side, frames the Doval-Wang track differently. "There is no evidence yet that the boundary dispute is any closer to being resolved," he says, "but all these moves are for the painstaking reconstruction of trust destroyed by Galwan." For Tangen, the real test of the early harvest is not whether it produces a dramatic settlement but whether it creates "durable stability". His formulation of the moment is disarmingly simple: "The task now is to manage the dispute so that it does not manage the relationship."

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY